

McFarlin's Discipline Brings Incentive

COMING FROM A military family, Richard Hildebrand was used to strict discipline during his adolescent years as a catcher at Irvin High School.

While the majority of prep baseball players fudged on hair codes, Hildebrand's crew-cut was easily recognized.

His batting average, which was around .500 his senior year in 1975, proved the skinhead wasn't dead. If opponents ever ridiculed Hildebrand's short hair, he shot them dead by rifling bullets down to second base on attempted steals.

Two years of junior college ball at Ranger under a strict disciplinary coach suited Hildebrand fine. Then he came to UTEP. Hildebrand's baseball career turned into a nightmare. The atmosphere at Minerland reminded him of a scene from "Animal House". Hildebrand thought he was in a zoo.

"We were always staying up until two or three in the morning," Hildebrand said, referring to his first season at UTEP last year. "When we were down in Abilene for a tournament, half the team got crocked the night before we played for the championship."

"It wasn't like that at the beginning of the season. Everybody busted their tails, but as the season went on, we lost our incentive. It's not that we didn't try. We all came from highly-disciplined junior colleges that were ranked high in the nation. We were expecting something better than what we had."

"THERE WAS SIMPLY no discipline," Hildebrand said. "Since practice was down by Western Playland every day, it took an hour just to travel back and forth from campus to practice. It started at 1:30 (p.m.) and was usually the time we left for practice. People would walk into practice whenever they wanted and nothing was ever said."

A sudden change in Hildebrand and the rest of his Miner teammates oc-



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curred during the fall when Larry McFarlin became UTEP's second baseball coach, replacing Andy Cohen, who had headed the program from 1963 until his retirement last summer.

McFarlin believes that if practice is scheduled for a certain time, you should be there. No exceptions. His players not only abide by the rules, they readily accept McFarlin's authoritative demands.

"We were frustrated as hell last year," Hildebrand continued. "All of us wanted to do more but there's not much you can do when practice is for an hour."

Enthusiasm and anticipation of reaching the Western Athletic Conference playoffs is extremely high among the Miner players since McFarlin took over the controls. No UTEP baseball team has ever entered postseason competition before.

"HE'S MY KIND of coach," said pitcher Jerry Walker. "He's a disciplinary coach and that's what we need. I truly feel we'll be in the playoffs."

McFarlin says his players' attitudes are positive. "You work for them, and they'll work for you."

Nowadays, Hildebrand says he and his teammates are hitting the sack no later than 11 p.m. "Everybody wants to work hard because we know we have a chance to win the conference. Coach McFarlin is having us do things we never did before. Take the other day for example. We spent two solid hours during practice just bunting. We never worked on that last year."

Baseball, at UTEP, has undergone some obvious changes under McFar-



... And Then Follows Put-Out Throw

lin. Hard work and strict discipline are the new coach's main ingredients

and, thus far, the players are receptive, eager and optimistic.